

AN OPENING ADDRESS · DAY 2 OF THE PROGRAMME

Communication, Culture, and *Artificial Intelligence*

Reflections on the Field, on the Moment, and on the Work Ahead

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A WELCOME FROM THE SCHOOL OF INTERNATIONAL COMMUNICATION

It is my privilege to *welcome you* to Beijing.

The Communication University of China has been engaged in the study of communication — its theories, its practices, and its global circulation — for more than half a century. Your presence here, as undergraduates from Ireland, is part of a longer conversation between our institutions and traditions. We do not take that lightly.

I would also like to acknowledge our partner colleagues in Ireland, whose work has made your journey here possible.

ON WHAT THIS HOUR IS

Not a lecture in the traditional sense.

An orientation.

I am not going to ask you to take notes on a body of theory. I am going to ask you to consider a few questions — questions that are, in fact, unsettled in our field, and that you will encounter, in concrete form, almost every day of the next ten.

THE QUESTION OF OUR TIME

How does meaning travel across borders today?

*This was the question of our field fifty years ago.
The answer has changed beyond recognition.*

A BRIEF INTELLECTUAL MAP

The field has *moved through paradigms*.

The press and broadcasting era. The cultural-imperialism debate of Schiller and his interlocutors. The turn to globalisation and flow. The platform era — what Castells called the *Network Society*.

And now, what I would suggest we call an emerging fourth paradigm: the era of synthetic media, in which the production of meaning itself is increasingly automated.

THREE STRUCTURAL FORCES OF OUR DECADE

Three forces distinguish the *present moment*.

I · THE PLATFORM

Enclosure

Communication today happens largely inside proprietary digital environments.

II · THE ALGORITHM

Computation

Distribution is no longer primarily editorial. It is computational.

III · THE MODEL

Generation

The act of producing text, image, voice, is now within the reach of large-scale AI systems.

CHINA'S DISTINCTIVE TRAJECTORY

China has lived through these transitions
in a *particular sequence*.

Many other societies passed through several decades of personal-computer-based media before encountering the mobile internet. China largely arrived at mobility first. The platform turn here is more deeply integrated with daily life — commerce, services, identity, communication — than in most other parts of the world. And the development of indigenous artificial intelligence capacity has, in the past three years, been remarkably rapid.

You will see this every day on the streets of Beijing. I would invite you to observe it not as foreign, but as instructive.

Six contemporary forms of *digital communication*.

I. The platform

Meituan, Alibaba — environments in which other actors transact

II. Algorithmic media

ByteDance, Douyin, TikTok — distribution as computation

III. Subscription media

iQIYI, Tencent Video, the AI services you will use this week

IV. Ecosystem architectures

Xiaomi, Huawei — integration across devices and contexts

V. Foundation models as service

DeepSeek, Wenxin, Doubao — the model itself as the offering

VI. AI-mediated persons

Baidu's Xiling digital humans — synthetic figures who communicate on behalf of organisations

WHERE YOU WILL ENCOUNTER EACH FORM

Walk into each setting
with this *map in mind*.

FORM	WHERE YOU WILL SEE IT
The platform	Daily life in Beijing — meal ordering, transportation, museum services
Algorithmic media	Open Douyin or TikTok during your stay; the editorial logic is different here
Subscription media	The AI music platforms you will use in the Day 5 workshop
Ecosystem architectures	Xiaomi visit, Day 4 — the architecture is the subject
Foundation models as service	The Chinese models you compare in the Day 4 LLM workshop — Wenxin, Doubao, DeepSeek
AI-mediated persons	Digital-human systems such as Xiling — synthetic communication, discussed as a case

A GENUINE THRESHOLD

For most of human history,
the production of meaning
required *time, training, and skill*.

A written article. A translated text. A composed image. A recorded performance. Each of these required human craft.

Today, increasingly, it does not. This is not merely a tool update. It is a structural change in the economy of meaning-making.

A MEASURABLE CHANGE · THE COST OF TRANSLATING ONE PAGE OF ENGLISH INTO CHINESE

A fall of *three orders of magnitude*
in ten years.

2015	€50.00	a human translator
2020	€5.00	a junior with machine assistance
2025	€0.05	a single model call

This is not a small change. It does not merely reduce expense. It reorganises who can communicate, at what scale, across which borders, and with what professional structures around the act.

THE CENTRAL QUESTION OF OUR DECADE

*If the production cost of cultural and
communicative work approaches zero,
what cultural work becomes worth doing?*

I would invite you to hold this question through the next ten days.

CHINESE CULTURE ACROSS TIME

For a thousand years,
Chinese culture travelled *slowly*.

The silk roads. Religious missions. Scholarly translation. Library collection. Museum loan.

Each transmission required *custodianship* — a person, an institution, a tradition that took responsibility for what was being conveyed and how.

THE NEW CONDITIONS OF CULTURAL CIRCULATION

Today, that same culture can be circulated
in a *sixty-second video*.

The constraint has shifted. The question is no longer whether culture can travel — clearly, it can. The question is what is worth sending, how it should be framed, who curates, who interprets, and to whom the work answers.

These are not technical questions. They are questions of communicative ethics, of responsibility, and of craft. They are the questions of our field.

A PROVOCATION

Consider three objects you will encounter in the next ten days:

A six-hundred-year-old hall in the Forbidden City.

A large language model capable of processing tens of trillions of tokens daily.

A translation that costs five cents to produce.

*What does international communication look like
when these three artefacts share a single room?*

I do not have a complete answer. Neither, I believe, does our field. Your work over the next ten days is, in part, an attempted small reply.

THE ARCHITECTURE OF YOUR PROGRAMME

Four pillars.

Each feeds the next.

I

Cultural Immersion

encountering a cultural source

II

The Corporate Visits

observing the contemporary architecture

III

The AI Workshops

practising the new craft

IV

The Final Work

producing an original work

Source → Architecture → Practice → Original work.

WHAT YOU WILL CREATE

A single coherent work in *three elements*.

I.

A research brief

Written in conversation with artificial intelligence — not by it. The text is yours; the inquiry is shared.

II.

An original composition

Music composed using AI tools, shaped by your cultural research and your own recordings from Beijing.

III.

An interactive work

A page on the open internet that audiences in Ireland can experience directly, in their own time.

Together, one coherent act of cultural communication — one that you have authored.

THREE OBSERVATIONS TO CARRY, DAILY

In every setting you enter,
ask three questions.

I. Whose voice is being amplified?
Whose voice is being filtered, or absent?

II. What is being produced — and, by the same act,
what is being lost or displaced?

III. Who is the audience,
and what is being asked of them?

These are not new questions in our field. But artificial intelligence has given them new urgency.

TWO QUESTIONS TO CARRY HOME

Before you return to Ireland,
I would be honoured by *your reply* to two questions.

I.

*What have you learned about communication in China
that you could not have learned anywhere else?*

II.

*What kind of communicator
do you hope to become?*

The second question, I confess, is the one I most hope you will spend time with.

IN CLOSING

The next ten days will ask you
to *listen carefully*, to *look closely*,
and to *make things*.

I have every confidence that you will rise to the occasion.

THANK YOU · QUESTIONS ARE WELCOME